

**Lost cause:** Even an unbeaten run similar to those seen in the recent past might not be enough for City to catch high-flying Liverpool at the top of the table. REUTERS

City will be buoyed by its 2-0 win against Leicester City in its final match of the year, and a busy January transfer window could very well rescue its season and secure a top-four finish.

Meanwhile, across the road, Manchester United has not fared well since shocking its city rival. Newly-appointed manager Ruben Amorim might feel he has bitten off more than he can chew after his side suffered successive defeats to Bournemouth, Wolves, and Newcastle United. For the first time in the Premier League era, United finished in the bottom half of the table at Christmas.

One of the major talking points of Amorim's tenure so far has been Marcus Rashford's exclusion from the team. The Portuguese coach has omitted Rashford (**left, below**) from the United squad in four of its last five games, starting with the derby, prompting the winger to admit that he is ready for a "new challenge."

Despite three of Rashford's four league goals this season coming under Amorim's tenure, a move away from his boyhood club in January is looking increasingly likely.

United ended the year 14th in the table.

### **Mbappe settles in at Real Madrid**

Any doubts regarding Kylian Mbappé's impact at Real Madrid were quashed by the Frenchman after he scored and assisted in its 3-0 win against Pachuca in the FIFA Intercontinental Cup 2024 final.

In its last league game before the winter break, against Sevilla, he recorded yet another goal and assist to propel the record winners to second place in the table, above arch-rival FC Barcelona.

Mbappé has now already won



two trophies with Real Madrid since his high-profile move in the summer from Paris Saint-Germain, scoring 13 goals and providing three assists in his 23 appearances so far.

His attacking partner Vinícius Júnior (**right**), on the other hand, was compensated for his Ballon d'Or snub after being named The Best FIFA Men's Player.

He became the first Brazilian and the third Real Madrid player to win the award after racking up 24 goals in 39 appearances last season while winning La Liga, the UEFA Champions League, and the Supercopa de España titles.

### **Super League returns; almost**

More than three and a half years later, the European Super League has re-emerged from the shadows, this time in a new avatar. Renamed the 'Unify League', sponsor A22 Sports Management announced that it had approached both FIFA and UEFA, requesting official recognition for the competition.

As an eye-catcher, the company revealed that the tournament, featuring 96 teams divided into four

**Impactful:** Kylian Mbappe scored and assisted in Real Madrid's 3-0 win against Pachuca in the FIFA Intercontinental Cup 2024 final. AP

